

“If you can make it here you can make it everywhere”

ABB CEO Morten Wierod on making the country a hub for complex, high-impact infrastructure projects and helping Indian companies go green

BY RICHA SHARMA

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ABB is a global name in electrification and automation technology. Its Indian subsidiary, which turned 75 this January, has evolved into one of its most dynamic and fastest-growing arms driving global innovation and technological excellence. CEO Morten Wierod, in an interview with Richa Sharma, talks about expansion and plans to make India the third-largest market in the next few years. Edited excerpts:

Q: How do you see ABB's growth in India?

A: Our business is one-third America, one-third Europe and one-third Asia. Today, the US and China are number one and number two, respectively, and India is number five. It is the same as their GDP (ranks), but with strong growth, India will be ABB's third-largest market in a few years. I always say that India is the most

important market, because if you win in India, you can win anywhere. It's a bit of Frank Sinatra: "If you can make it here, you can make it everywhere."

Our technology centre in Bengaluru, with over 3,000 experts in engineering and R&D, plays a vital role in supporting Indian and global projects. From electrifying offshore oil platforms in the North Sea to large LNG infrastructure projects, much of the critical engineering, automation, and panel manufacturing happens here. This highlights India's strength as a hub for executing complex, high-impact infrastructure projects.

Our unit in India takes care of regional exports. If you are a market leader in India, you have the scale, the competitiveness and the know-how to go outside.

Q: Do you plan to enter new sectors?

A: It will depend on a combination of factors—identifying new opportunities early and helping existing customers with targets, for instance in the cement and steel industry. I met Hindalco, Tata Steel and Reliance and they all are looking at capacity expansion. In steel, there is competition from Chinese imports. So, they (steel companies) need to stay competitive, expand, and decarbonise operations. We are helping them in electrification and automation for decarbonising fossil fuel-based power generators so that they can produce more steel with lower cost and emissions. It's a steep challenge but I'm impressed with what I've seen (in India) on the green side with the use of solar and wind power and plans to get into small modular nuclear reactors.